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READING THE GENERIC CITY

RETROACTIVE MANIFESTOS FOR GLOBAL CITIES OF THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY

Esra Akcan

I.

In 1993, Rem Koolhaas traveled 360,000 kilometers, spent 305 nights in a hotel, and made the information public to call attention to the rising impact of traveling on the architectural profession in the age of globalization.[1] Ever since, he has published copious books, essays, and exhibition pamphlets that have gone well beyond travel diaries and have come to illustrate a new type of *research* on the city. This research is collected in publications that are no longer written by an author but by a big team, AMO, which defines itself as a research and design studio that applies architectural thinking to disciplines beyond the borders of architecture and urbanism.[2]

Why do architects travel and record what they see? Three impulses suggest themselves: The first is the impulse of the Grand Tour. Architects travel to study the masterpieces of Architecture, to learn from the great minds of the past. They record what they see in order to remember the buildings that have somehow proved their worthwhile existence. Such travel notes will provide the confidence that any architect needs in moments of weakness, ensuring them that it has once been possible to build artifacts with an aura, and it should thus be possible again. The second is the impulse of the meticulous and persistent diary keeper. Everything is worth recording in this case. Small vernacular buildings, buildings with no name, randomly created irregular streets are no less collectible than monuments with an aura. Unlike the permanent residents of the town who go ahead with their usual lives without paying attention to the mundane details, the traveler-architects with this sensibility record everything they see. They collect unconditionally, regardless of privilege. Everything is equally important, perhaps too important, by virtue of the fact that they are there. There is nevertheless a third type: travelers that have an uneasy dissatisfaction with their own world, whose reflections or alternatives they seek in the travel destination.

These impulses map concurrently with Friedrich Nietzsche's theories of writing about the past. In his book *On the Advantage and Disadvantage of History for Life,* the philosopher specified three genres of history that would be applied by three types of individuals with different sensibilities.[3] Those who want to be powerful lean toward monumental history and consider only the major accomplishments and heroes of the past worthy of study. The errors of great heroes are excused in monumental history for the sake of maintaining their mythic status. Here "the past must be described as something worthy of imitation, something that can be imitated for the second time, so long, at least, is the past in danger of being somewhat distorted, of being reinterpreted according to aesthetic criteria and so brought closer to fiction."[4] The second type of history is favored by individuals with antiquarian sensibilities. This type of historians are patiently archivist; they collect all possible documents without official selection criteria, not realizing that it is impossible to run away from making choices.[5] The utopia of the antiquarian is to reconstruct the past without value judgment, even if it is categorically impossible to relive each and every second of life for the second time. In addition to monumental and antiquarian attitudes toward the past, there is also a legitimate need for a third kind of history, the critical history, written by those who feel the need to condemn the past. "[O]nly he who is oppressed by some present misery and wants to throw off the burden at all cost has a need for critical, that is judging and condemning history."[6] These are the creatively destructive or destructively creative historians who want change.

These three kinds of Nietzschean history mapped onto the three impulses of the traveler-architect can be summarized as follows: the impulse to record only the

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most important buildings, to record everything, and to record in order to change. A specific mixture of all three impulses can of course exist in the same traveler.

In his research on world cities, Rem Koolhaas is consistently attracted to "virtually unknown" architects rather than ones with an *aura,* he records buildings conceived and constructed by a mass of builders rather than stars, by producers rather than authors. His thick books with countless snapshots seem to have an antiquarian obsession with the ordinary bits and pieces of the city, rather than its most memorable monuments. How can one explain, then, Rem Koolhaas's own comfort in stardom, and his own desire to design buildings that always stand out in the crowd? Koolhaas seems to have antiquarian sensibilities as a researcher and monumental ones as an architect. Is he a monumental researcher staging as an antiquarian, or an antiquarian architect staging as a monumental? Or, may we say that the confrontational sensibilities in his writing and public persona best explain the work as a whole as some sort of criticism? Many of Koolhaas's texts, including the ones resulting from research travels, read like manifestos, throwing harsh assaults at the established values of the profession and, at times, at the choices of the majority.

Using the word "critical" today (in an age considered "postcritical" or "projective," but *only* based on two specific definitions of criticality), especially in relation to Koolhaas (the architect who is usually the first to be singled out by the advocates of postcriticality),[7] brings with it baggage, and that is exactly why I would like to insist on using it, albeit cautiously. As Nietzsche also warned in the same book, "much harm is caused by… the critic without need."[8] What is the "need" in Koolhaas's confrontational style? Is there a consistent position, a project for change that comes out of his *oeuvre?* Is Koolhaas's apparent confrontational style a veil to mask the end of the possibility of criticism in the "post-critical" age and turn this new condition into an opportunity for functioning as an architect in the market (a possible explanation of course, but one that will not be entertained in this article), or can we still define critical perspectives (by looking at Koolhaas or not) as long as we do not narrow down the meaning of criticality into a specific Western discourse? Let me take a detour by reading Koolhaas's article The Generic City in relation to his work on the generic cities of New York, Singapore, Lagos, the Pearl River Delta, and the Persian Gulf in order to answer this question. Even though Koolhaas openly declared inconsistency as a liberating impulse for the intellectual,[9] and at times retreated into ambivalence himself, it is nevertheless possible to observe repeating patterns in his publications on the city that lead to a consistent explanation.

II.

Rem Koolhaas's earliest manifesto on globalization (1993) was set next to a photograph of a very decipherable "anthropological" image, portraying a semidressed man and woman of color in a jungle standing in front of their basic shelter with primal tools in hand.[10] These formulaic signs of "primitive culture" must have meant to imply the coming of a new age when architects would be working with "other cultures," just like old-school anthropologists. And surely after a few pages, Koolhaas wrote: Sometime in 1987, in our office, international projects and collaborators began to form a majority. Suddenly OMA was global, not in the form of multiple offices turning out a single 'product' but of one involved more and more deeply in other cultures. We became experts in difference.[11] In one of the earliest accounts on the impact of globalization on architecture, Koolhaas thus spoke about globalization's professional possibilities that enabled architects to find a market of commissions in any part of the world on the one hand, and, on the other hand, the emerging necessity to understand the new contexts in which they would have to operate. In the next decade, Koolhaas's ideas on globalization gradually moved away from a fascination with professional opportunities toward an emphasis on learning "non-Western" cities.[12] In explaining his pedagogic activities at Harvard, Koolhaas stated that it would be probably much better to suspend design education for ten years, and to introduce ten years of solid research.[13] His book *Mutations* was not about design, he declared, in which the architect is asked to intervene in, but never to appreciate or understand a given situation; on the contrary, it was about pure research on the urban conditions of world cities.[14] This period of pure research soon came to a close when OMA secured major commissions in the places of research, such as CCTV in Beijing and eleven ongoing projects in the Middle East. Nevertheless, Koolhaas and AMO's activity to understand world cities is continuing. The books that come out of this exploration aim to overthrow the received values of the city and replace them with a new set of hitherto unusual ones.

However, "learning other cultures" is a fragile anthropological territory. Being interested in the "non-West" is not a value in itself, unless one can differ from the ages-old accounts of Orientalist writers and travelers who constructed the Western stereotypes about "exotic" lands, on the one hand, and unless one is genuinely committed to avoiding any cultural imperialist implication, on the other hand.

Koolhaas had already started research on cities in *Delirious New York* (1978), where he developed an argument that was never abandoned, and which therefore has to be treated as the foundational book of his theory on the global city.[15] Choosing Manhattan as the archetype of the Metropolitan Condition[16]—one that needed a different theoretization than the turn-of-the-century metropolis—Koolhaas observed high density and the resulting culture of congestion as the major metropolitan charm at the end of the twentieth century. In Manhattan, both the nameless yet experimental vacationing structures in Coney Island and the ideas of the skyscraper theorists, who stacked multiple realities and simultaneous private experiences on top of each other, created a culture of congestion that exploited density to inspire and support particular forms of social intercourse.[17] These unordinary, eccentric, and stimulating social intercourses were indeed illustrated with numerous examples in *Delirious New York:* Koolhaas demonstrated to us the charm of eating oysters with boxing gloves, naked, on the 9th floor of the Downtown

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Athletic club; fighting the loneliness and alienation of the metropolis with the accidental partner with whom you have fallen into the same rotating horizontal cylinders of the Barrels of Love; coming to terms with the unnaturalness of the urban condition by sunbathing on the artificially lit beach of the electrifying Coney Island. *Delirious New York* was a historical research, albeit an unconventional one that was equally enthusiastic about obscure unbuilt projects in the depths of archives and architects' costume balls where they dressed up as skyscrapers. Koolhaas's usual confrontational style against the values of the architectural profession had transformed into a deep affection here for the informal products and practices of Manhattan, which received less disciplinary attention. Just as the avant-gardes of the early metropolitan condition, Koolhaas challenged the conventional view that undervalued the metropolis with a sense of anguish and dissent, instead suggesting that the unique metropolitan architecture would come out of this culture of congestion.

In New York, Koolhaas discovered two unconventional conditions that had transformed the way buildings were produced and consumed, and for which, I shall argue, he looked again and again in the "non-Western" global cities. The first was the decreasing role of the professional architects in shaping the interior performance of their buildings due to the high urban density that compressed multiple worlds and incommensurable individual lives in one skyscraper:

> Through the medium of the Skyscraper, each site in the Metropolis accommodates—in theory at least—an unstable and unforeseeable combination of superimposed and simultaneous activities whose configuration is fundamentally beyond the control of architect or planner.[18]

Architecture's conventional tools that aspired to shape the future and regulate lives by determining a stable physical order were now falling way short in living up to the instability of the metropolis. Later in *S,M,L,XL,* Koolhaas would summarize his argument for New York as follows: The permanence of even the most frivolous item of architecture and the instability of the metropolis are incompatible. In this conflict the metropolis is, by definition, the victor.[19] Architects were losing control and authorship. The resulting environment was much more charming.

The second related condition was the impossibility of imposing a prescriptive order on New York, which ended up being its asset rather than liability:

> ...the authors of the Regional Plan know instinctively that it would be suicide to solve Manhattan's problems, that they exist by the grace of these problems, that it is their duty to make its problems, if anything, forever insurmountable, that the only solution for Manhattan is the extrapolation of its freakish history, that Manhattan is the city of the perpetual *flight forward.*[20]

For Koolhaas, New York in its heyday (i.e., not after the reactions to September 11)[21] was an archetype of the new city because it escaped human prediction, bureaucratic tidiness, and conventional organization logic, yet its residents always came up with a practical ad hoc solution. The strength of the metropolitan architects would be their ability to confront this disorder and messy conditions with no sense of determinist intervention, and to treat chaos as an opportunity for a new architecture that would embrace the instable and dynamic urban experience.

III.

Let me now suggest, with the unavoidable harshness of any containment act, that in his future work, Rem Koolhaas reworked these two related conditions, and theorized the first as junk and the second as mutant space, which together characterize the generic city. What unites Koolhaas's depiction of these cities is the fact that inhabitants in all of them have come up with creative ways of living in cultures of congestion and, especially, with forms of unspecific and unstable buildings.

The Generic City (1994), published in *S,M,L,XL,* was a depiction of the city that comes out of the global capital. Due to the impact of the economic transformations brought by globalization, some cities are expanding, others are shrinking. The Generic City seems to be a theory about the first category, and so are the exemplary cities Koolhaas picked to illustrate his theory that confirmed or adjusted his observations. The abstract account on the generic city was thus filled in with Koolhaas's "retroactive manifestos" on different world cities.

The Generic City was a testimony to the contemporary loss of identity as long as identity is created by the past. But the fact that human growth is exponential implies that the past will at some point become too 'small' to be inhabited and shared by those alive.[22] Koolhaas theorized the contemporary city, the one created by us in the present moment, as the city which is emancipated from an identity that imprisons...resists expansion, interpretation, renewal, contradiction, an identity that centralizes [and] insists on an essence.[23] The generic city is the city without history. It is big enough for everybody. It is easy. It does not need maintenance. If it gets too small it just expands. If it gets old it just self-destructs and renews. It is equally exciting—or unexciting—everywhere.[24]

The generic city, set against the artificially preserved traditional European city, such as Paris and Zurich—the two examples Koolhaas cited in the article—signaled the coming of a new age generating from America and Asia. Did the Generic City start in America? Is it so profoundly unoriginal that it can only be imported? In any case...a large proportion of Generic cities is Asian.[25]

Singapore was exemplified in *S,M,L,XL* as a generic city (the text was written in 1995, only a year after The Generic City), a city less than thirty years old, uncontaminated by contextual remnants,[26] a city without qualities,[27] a completely fabricated island that developed fast over a tabula rasa with unforeseen opportunities to build new vertical housing, mixed-use skyscrapers, tower car-parks, connected atriums with creative forms of urban linkages. Like the generic city, when Singapore got too small, it just expanded with the major landfills that significantly changed its natural geography. Koolhaas chose to bring to the fore SPUR (Singapore Planning and Urban Research Group, formed by William Lim and

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Tay Kheng Soon) because the "Asian" as a sign of local identity was nothing but a "sentimental diversion" for them (in those days), while congestion and density were the true signifiers of their city. In Koolhaas's words, It is exactly this "new" density—the high-rise explosion of which the HBD housing blocks were only the beginning—that will be the sign of the Asian.[28] Koolhaas intuited the hints of Manhattan's early urban delirium in Singapore. In its heyday, Singapore was the first city where one could discover a new Asian self-awareness and confidence...they are containers of urban multiplicity, heroic captures and intensifications of urban life in *architecture.*[29]

Additionally, Koolhaas predicted Singapore as the *Hermes* of the next China, and by extension, as the model generic city where the majority of the world population would soon reside:

> In numerous architectural offices in Singapore, whose names few of us have ever heard, China's future is being prepared. In these countless new cities the skyscraper is the only surviving typology...Projecting outward from Singapore, an asymmetrical epicenter, there will be new Singapores across the entire mainland. Its model will be the stamp of China's modernization.
>
> Two billion people can't be wrong.[30]

The Generic City was more than its author's travel notes exploring reality, but rather a manifesto for the future coming out of the experience of traveling. Despite the lack of open reference, Aldo Rossi was the father figure that Koolhaas constantly rebelled against: the memory of the traditional European city was not at all worth preserving, and contemporary architects needed to be emancipated from the task of establishing continuity with the conventional urban environment. Rather than maintaining the unity, harmony, memory, or identity of historical cities, Koolhaas called for the metropolis of ultimate excitement, creative forgetting, disconnection from history, and unpredictability.

Nevertheless, the generic city in Koolhaas's observations was neither without new identities nor a homogenous whole. It was multiracial and multicultural.[31] Architectural reflections of different identities could thus be observed side by side in the most unexpected and unpredictable ways. The Generic City is the apotheosis of the multiple-choice concept: all boxes crossed, an anthology of *all* the options.[32] The category of difference needs some clarification in Koolhaas's various pieces. In his earlier accounts Koolhaas defined the generic city as the general city, the city without qualities, the city without identity,[33] but this was not meant as a call against difference. On the contrary, in his work on Lagos and the cities of Pearl River Delta and the Persian Gulf, Koolhaas differentiated the traditional city from the generic city in terms of the former's homogeneity as opposed to the latter's hybridity. Koolhaas identified the five Chinese cities of the Pearl River Delta as the City of Exacerbated Difference (COED), namely a new urban coexistence where every city defines itself in terms of difference from the other cities and always renews its differences in order to survive:[34]

> The traditional city strives for a condition of balance, harmony and a degree of homogeneity. The City of Exacerbated Difference, on the contrary, is based on the greatest possible difference between its parts—complementary or competitive.[35]

A few years later, Koolhaas made the same observation for Lagos: Lagos is perhaps very similar to the City of Exacerbated Difference (COED) that I identified in the Pearl River Delta in China. It is perhaps the only sustainable model of the city—a city that consists of radically different parts that define themselves in relation to all the others, and that coexist through the interactions between all components.[36]

The Generic City is thus not necessarily a familiar declaration on the homogenization of the world, but rather an abstraction—a theoretical statement—on the transformation of the concept of a city as a result of globalization's complex forces, both homogenizing and differentiating, as well as a statement on the differences between the global city and the conventional Eurocentric definition of "the city." What best defines the generic is not therefore the loss of difference and identity, but the elimination of identity defined by the past, and more significantly the loss of control that used to be attained with conventional architectural and urban planning tools. The generic city is unpredictable, it abandons what doesn't work,[37] its multiple centers can move anywhere, it can expand or shrink in any direction, it signals the death of city planning as we used to know it. Not because it is not planned...But its most dangerous *and* most exhilarating discovery is that planning makes no difference whatsoever.[38] In that sense, the generic city resembles the skyscraper, as Koolhaas once saw it. Architects and planners are now losing control and authorship in shaping not only the interior performance of their buildings, as they did in Manhattan, but also the overall environment.

In his essay What Ever Happened to Urbanism?—written in the same year as The Generic City, in 1994—Koolhaas pointed out the paradox that urban planning as a profession was becoming inadequate exactly at the moment when the population of world cities were tripling.[39] This was all the more reason to understand how these existing world cities worked and, through their appreciation, to offer alternative ways of approaching the city other than the modernist norms of city planning. What if we simply declare that there *is* no crisis—redefine our relationship with the city not as its makers but as its mere subjects, as its supporters?[40]

Junkspace was another Koolhaasian term that depicted the proliferation of anonymous and nameless buildings, as well as the decreasing control of the designer-architect. As part of his research on shopping, Koolhaas used it to come to terms with the abundance of shopping malls, airports, multistory car parks, and theme parks, about which he remained conflicted and ironic, half fascinated, half traumatized.[41] Junkspace is nothing mysterious; it is what we see when we look out of the window of any building in a modern city. The built product of modernization is not modern architecture, but Junkspace. The form of Koolhaas's text mimics its content: it is claustrophobic. Junkspace is composed of one single paragraph; page after page, sentence after sentence, one continuously reads about the repetitive cycles of endless, anonymous, unspecific junkspaces.

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The text weighs on the reader like a David Lynch movie, where one feels trapped in a space with many exists but no exterior. Every time you burst out of a building (i.e., a junkspace), you find yourself in another one. Junkspace is everywhere. Yet, like all good fiction writers, Koolhaas is able to compose the most interesting story out of our least attractive real world and dull lives. Where you see a big flat building with no windows, or countless concrete apartment slabs with no differentiation, Rem sees a perpetual Jacuzzi with millions of your best friends.[42] And like all fiction novels or travel diaries that inherit their writer's imaginative twist, the readers should enjoy the text, get inspired if they wish, but be cautious of believing it.

The anonymity of junkspace does not mean it manifests itself as the same environment in every city. For instance, in their latest book *Al Manakh,* AMO members continued to identify the anonymous architecture of the Persian Gulf states, including Kuwait, Bahrain, Qatar, Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, and Ras al-Khaimah, as the nameless but spectacular buildings conceived as a result of the collaboration between "virtually unknown" architects, engineers, and developers:

> Other architects are responsible for their own foundering in irrelevance. While Western architecture has focused on convincing itself on its singularity and pursuing the next strange form, a more intelligent system has perfected its so-called art into an algorithm. The building industry—where engineer, architect and even developer are once again united in one entity—has caught up to neutralize the difference between the brand name and a more efficient, generic alternative... In a time frame of three weeks, a Virtually Unknown can generate the thrill that the brand-name architect couldn't even do in twelve months...this is architecture's redefinition, whether it is welcome or not.[43]

The anonymous, neutral, and familiar space of Dubai is slick and sophisticated, while that of Lagos is chaotic and dynamic. In either case, however, the "junkspace" is created beyond the designer's control out of the complex global forces acting on that particular city. In summary, anonymous buildings, designed by virtually unknown professionals, are taking over the generic city regardless of their prescriptive urban plans. The death of the author has never been so evident.

If the elimination of a fixed, single, and past identity previously sought by using conventional tools is the first major attribute of the generic city, the capability to mutate and adapt to the fast and perpetually changing conditions is the second. In Manhattan, the impact of the unstable metropolis influenced only the interior performance of the skyscrapers, while the envelope remained fixed. Skyscrapers combined the aura of monumentality with the performance of instability because their interiors accommodate[d] compositions of program and activity that change constantly and independently of each other without affecting what is called, with accidental profundity, the envelope.[44] Manhattan thus kept the illusion of architecture intact,[45] whereas the Asian and African global cities make the disillusionment complete. In *Delirious New York,* Koolhaas illustrated examples of the ever-changing interior organizations that constantly adapted and re-adapted to the instability of the metropolis. In *Mutations,* he came to terms with the practical ad hoc solutions of a city that escapes bureaucratic order. Cities of Pearl River Delta and Lagos—exemplary cities from Asia and Africa—are in constant mutation, and they rely on mutation as a new organizational skill, rather than a prescribed conventional order:

> The fundamental conundrum of Lagos, considered as both paradigm and pathological extreme of the West African city, is its continued existence and productivity in spite of a near-complete absence of those infrastructures, systems, organizations, and amenities that define the word "city" in terms of Western planning methodology. Lagos, as an icon of West African urbanity, inverts every essential characteristic of the so-called modern city. Yet, it is still—for the lack of a better word—a city that works.[46]

So, how does Lagos work, despite the apparent malfunctioning of the conventional infrastructures and urban organizations that make up a "city"? It works through mutating operations and adopting agents that would be considered "marginal, liminal, informal or illegal" according to Eurocentric definitions, but that together construct a totally exciting organizational system. Property lines constantly change in Lagos, so do the building typologies; crime prevention techniques have sparked new industries; the walls built as security gates host casual trades; informal public and commercial spaces never remain static; the garbage of the city is totally disassembled through semi-official businesses and reused in the Nigerian economy; the most crucial industries, storage and parking functions, take place by temporarily occupying the land underneath the highways or undersides of overpasses and by adhering to the highway columns as space regulators; major trade in the city happens during the manipulated traffic jams[47]: Jamspace, the totally negotiable, usually illegal and hugely productive space of the traffic jam, is not something to fix, solve or even rationalize.[48]

Koolhaas made similar observations for the Persian Gulf cities in *Al Manakh.* The Gulf city is no longer generated by a plan; it has become a patchwork of developers' increments...Infrastructure is no longer conceptual anticipation, but pragmatic afterthought.[49] Like major Chinese metropolises, the most determining actuality of the Persian Gulf's building practice is its overwhelming speed. In a series of interviews Koolhaas and AMO's Todd Reisz conducted with past and current planners of the Gulf cities, it is revealed that master plans get prepared on the basis of construction that had already started; coincidental anecdotes shape the future much more than plans.

The uniqueness of Koolhaas's travel and research accounts on Lagos and Dubai was not only his perceptive observations of these cities, but also his prediction that all cities, European cities included, would sooner or later adopt these mutant urban organization strategies.

> The Gulf is the current frontline of rampant modernization...If you want to be apocalyptic, you could construe Dubai as evidence of the end-of-architecture-and-the-city-as-we-know-them; more optimistically you could detect in the emerging substance of The Gulf—constructed and proposed—the beginnings of a new

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architecture and a new city.[50] Or should I have said that Koolhaas's desire to inflict a *change* so that the static and slow European cities also mutate into the dynamic and speedy Lagos and Dubai determined his descriptions? In Koolhaas's eyes, Lagos and the Persian Gulf are not the developing African and Middle Eastern cities on their way to Westernization. On the contrary,

> Lagos is not catching up with us. Rather we may be catching up with Lagos.[51]
>
> The Gulf is not just reconfiguring itself; it is reconfiguring the world.[52]

IV.

In the face of these copious, abundant, and accumulative data on world cities, the question remains: Despite their differences, why do generic cities saturate our planet at this particular moment in world history? Is this the natural result of our global age, of our technology, or of our political convictions? Namely, is this the unavoidable architecture of not only democracy and multinational capitalism, but also (ex-)socialism as well as monarchy? Is this the architecture of majority or of surplus value created by deviation from fair exchange now exerted at a global level? Even though Koolhaas continuously consoles himself that he is receptive to reality and turns it into an opportunity for his architectural practice, just as he did after his book *Delirious New York,* he is also aware of the claustrophobic oppression of junkspace. If we start seeing the generic city as a potentially oppressive force (whether Koolhaas agrees or not), would this make it a "tyranny of majority" or a tyranny of G8? In either case, this would mean that the built environment lacks some of the mediums that are analogous to the political spaces devised to contest these hegemonies, such as minority spaces, free speech, and the public sphere. If so, wouldn't this mean that architecture as a profession and discipline needs new mediums similar to the social institutions that create hope for a more functioning democracy, a less oppressive market, and global equality? Are we really over criticism?

Any research on globalization and global cities around the whole world can hardly escape geopolitical questions. The political implications of Koolhaas's work can best be discussed by tracing his statements chronologically, because it is possible to intuit a shift in his answers. While his descriptions of the cities remained more or less constant in relation to the two themes outlined above, his recent accounts began adopting a more explicitly stated political perspective.

The Generic City, written in 1994, asserted to be a neutral description of sheer facts, but it was written from the perspective of the global elite. The global elite travel for work from one generic city to another, which are all internationally connected with familiar airports. The global elite spend their nights at glamorous hotels—the quintessential places of domestic irresponsibility where customers do not have to make the bed, clean up, or hang the towel. And the global elite shop, not simply as a form of necessary exchange, which is painful if you have limited means, but as a form of leisure. These three programs that Koolhaas listed as the basic architectural types of the generic city—the airport, the hotel, and the shopping mall—are the most controlled and surveilled spaces of our times and are therefore unlikely to host a public sphere (i.e., a sphere for free speech).

In The Generic City, Koolhaas was evasive and ambivalent, refusing to take sides about the recent developments of globalization. The article can be read both as a satire and a celebration. Koolhaas's affection as a global *flâneur* for the generic city was sort of a Baudelairian "love at last sight," both outside and inside, both suspicious and fascinated, both resistant and welcoming, both reserved and seduced, both critical and antiquarian. However, unlike Benjamin's characterizations of Baudelaire's reception of mass culture in the metropolis, Koolhaas's ambivalence served to depoliticize the discourse at this stage. Koolhaas did not take sides; he could (and still can) work in any ideological context, with leaders from any mainstream or extreme political conviction; he could survive in any governmental structure.

Even though AMO's thick books record infinite data of the real, Koolhaas, like all committed avant-gardes perhaps, is persistently drawn to the concept of tabula rasa on which new identities can be inscribed.[53] All Generic Cities issue from the tabula rasa; if there was nothing, now they are there; if there was something, they have replaced it.[54] Koolhaas is most curious about cities at their moment of booming from a tabula rasa: New York in the 1920s and 1930s, Singapore in the 1960s, Lagos in the 1970s, the Pearl River Delta in the 1990s, Dubai in the 2000s. He dumps them once dynamism dies: New York after the World Trade Center architectural competition, Singapore after its Promethean hangover. When there is a chance to start over, Koolhaas is there.

However, many crucial issues get sidetracked during this fascination with cities that emerge or change suddenly. Anthony Vidler had already pointed out the facetious but ignorant tone in *Delirious New York:* "For how should we laugh, for example, at the spectacle of positive projects like that of the 'Fighting the Flames' event on Coney Island juxtaposed to the actual fire that destroyed the fairground in 1911, a fair created for pleasure at the expense of the masses and contrasting with their degradation?"[55] Many more examples can be listed: The ecological problems to be caused by Dubai's landfills were not even mentioned in *Al Manakh* during the applause for the mega projects "The World" and "The Palm," even though the data by AMO itself in the same book proves the alarming ecological footprint of the region.[56] To give another example, Koolhaas was bound to disregard any design potential in, for example, Singapore's tropical architecture as a result of his inflexible rejection of local identity.[57]

Koolhaas is usually reluctant to confront the serious problems of these generic cities, which in turn exoticizes them as the alternative to the conventional European city that he is so eager to contest. The biggest risk of such travelers' accounts is their exoticism. In looking for an alternative to their own world, they can so easily fall into the condescending exoticism of the Orientalist traveler.[58] For example, *S,M,L,XL* was embarrassingly filled with the cliché Orientalist stereotypes: If it [Generic City] is Asian, then 'delicate' (sensual, inscrutable)

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women appear in elastic poses, suggesting (religious, sexual) submission everywhere.[59] To give another example, Koolhaas whined over the fact that there were no sensual, demure, provocatively innocent pre-geishas any more.[60]

Residues of this exoticism remained in the future work. While this will likely be avoided in the forthcoming book on Lagos, in his earlier accounts Koolhaas aestheticized the city's slums as heavens of self-organization creatively mutating to cope with the extreme complexities of global conditions. However, other accounts tell a different story: "As a picture of the urban future, Lagos is fascinating only if you are able to leave it. After just a few days in the city's slums, it is hard to maintain Koolhaas's intellectual excitement. What he calls 'self-organization' is simply collective adaption to extreme hardship."[61] Or in Okwui Enwezor's words, "there is a sense that the attentiveness to these conditions in Lagos tends to focus less on a principle of empathy and more on the erotics of chaos and gigantic flux."[62] While the reader searches desperately in Koolhaas's early work for the voice of Lagos's inhabitants, their dilemmas, and economical, psychological, and health problems, complicated responses to the histories of colonization, and complex relations with the current world powers, Koolhaas loves Lagos because it is resilient, material-intensive, decentralized and congested, and because it does away with the inherited notion of 'city' once and for all.[63] Aren't these the very attributes he was promoting long before he went to Lagos? Lagos seems to justify and prove the necessity for the "new city" Koolhaas had been projecting for years.[64]

Similarly, AMO celebrates Dubai as the world's most intricate and simultaneously flat-footed system of cross-cultural coexistence.[65] However, this elite multinational population is maintained at the expanse of millions of guest workers whose immigration status and working and living conditions in this tax-free land do not match current standards for international workers' rights (even if, we are told, there is improvement in this area). While Koolhaas admits cosmopolitanism as the biggest asset of world cities, he is reluctant to expose the tensions in Dubai that prevent a true cosmopolitan coexistence, such as the continuing hierarchies of an ethnic caste that puts the South Asian groups (the majority in the overall population) at a disadvantage.

If, in fact, Koolhaas is seeking confirmation for his preceding ideas during his travels, he would be less a migrant traveler who learns and changes in relation to the place of arrival and more a nomad traveler who carries and brings his place of departure (i.e., his project) to the place of arrival.[66] This is the basic symptom of all imperial impulses when it is directed toward hitherto disenfranchised geographies, however hidden or involuntary it may be, and however sincerely committed Koolhaas may be to the production of a non-Eurocentric architecture culture.

P.S. Alternative Ending

It is only in some of his recent publications that Koolhaas, together with key figures in AMO, openly confronted the drawbacks of exoticism and a hidden epistemic hegemony. Signs of change radiated from Koolhaas after September 11 as well, when his political choices became a bit sharper. It is still unclear to me whether this shift was intentionally committed to a political and ethical responsibility or whether it was a natural result of Koolhaas's reactionary attitude to the authority figures of culture. In any event, after September 11, we found Koolhaas making more and more comments with a critical sensibility against North American cultural hegemony. Due to his work with the European Union, Koolhaas increasingly commented on Europe, but now with a decreased sense of appreciation for Western hegemony. The Europe of the EU would not be the Europe that Koolhaas openly found so boring in his early career. It would be a new Europe in the making; and meanwhile not only the American but also the "non-Western" cities would offer new possibilities for imagining the future of global cities. Koolhaas was exceptionally progressive (and deliberately fictional) in opening the borders of EU to practically any country who wants to be part of it: If I were the foreign minister of EU, I would ignore Europe. I would simply assume that, for my domain, bigger is better…I would work with the Chinese to construct a Eurasian arc, which would be a new inclusive framework that could eventually accommodate every nation belonging to this landmass into a Judeo-Christian-Islamic-Hindu-Confucian belt of compatibility.[67]

The forthcoming book on Lagos, prepared by Talia Dorsey from AMO, not only observes the current self-organizing systems, but also examines the city's large development projects in the 1970s, just a decade after it gained independence, as forms of a "higher intelligence." The two "blueprints" of the city, the one created in the 1970s by the urban planners, and the other one added in time by the residents, together create new forms of self-organization. AMO will argue that Lagos can function despite all odds thanks to the combined intelligence of the urban planners and the additions made afterward by the inhabitants.[68] The fact that a preemptive higher intelligence could be inscribed in the master plans, which later enabled the city to adjust to the demands of its own dynamism, may actually restore Koolhaas's disenchantment with urban planning, and may in turn change the tone about the perceived impossibility of the architect's critical participation.

To give another example, in an admirable essay, Koolhaas and Reinier de Graaf from AMO discuss the education policy in the Persian Gulf (as well as the dangers of the U. S.'s exclusionary practices in this field after September 11) and reach a point where they admit the necessity to question the Western narrowness of some of the very frameworks of knowledge:

> Human rights, corruption, freedom of speech, free trade, nuclear arms proliferation, and copyright. Undoubtedly many of these values and concepts currently considered to be universal will, in the long run, turn out to have been too narrowly defined—i.e., only from a Western perspective. In order to acquire

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true universal status, they will have to be renegotiated and become subject of a global debate...Maybe the real Enlightenment is still ahead of us.[69]

If I am in fact correct that Koolhaas is envisioning a transformed world where ages-old cultural hegemonies and hierarchies are transformed, he would be doing far more than recording reality but engaging in a practice that is willing to try making a true change, i.e., critical practice *par excellence:*

Is it possible to view the Gulf's ongoing transformation in its own terms?

As an extraordinary attempt to change the fate of an entire region?

Is it possible to present a constructive criticism to these phenomena?

Is there something like a critical participation?[70]

A traveler who lands in "non-Western" countries today is faced with the double challenge of avoiding both exoticism and being judgmental based on Eurocentric values. In a world where societies are getting more and more immune to the wars that justify themselves with numerous stereotypes of the "clash of civilizations" ideology, this double challenge is tripled with a responsibility for criticism. While discussing forms of postcriticality and their limitations, Roemer van Toorn writes: "Instead of chasing after elusive ideals, we prefer to surf the turbulent waves of free-market global capitalism...Thus many reflective architects believe that it no longer makes any sense to spend time constructing new ideologies or criticizing the 'system'...[D]reaming is no longer necessary since even our wildest dreams are incapable of predicting how inspiring, chaotic, liberating and dynamic reality can be."[71] For a world citizen who is outside the global architectural elite, such as one living in the slums of Lagos partly because architecture/city culture stopped investing in alternatives, or another one who is under the continuous threat of being bombed in the name of "freedom" in Baghdad, Beirut, or another Middle Eastern city, or one who lived through the deadly earthquake in Istanbul in spite of the ignorance and corruption in building industry, or one who endured a similar negligence in New Orleans, the reality is obviously not as "inspiring and liberating." Nietzsche's critical historian does not take the world at face value, because the world is "oppressed by some present misery." Fighting against the "system" of capitalism or staying in the "autonomous" sphere of architecture are obviously not the only forms of criticality. Suggesting that "architects gave up the critical project because it proved to be too unrealistic and, besides, reality is gorgeous" may sound like a mean joke to those who are inside the oppressive reality or those who empathize. Observing and recording the reality of world cities today unavoidably calls for new forms of criticism.

1 Rem Koolhaas, *S,M,L,XL* (New York: Monacelli Press, 1998), xiii.

2 Ole Bouman, Mitra Khoubrou, and Rem Koolhaas, eds., *Al Manakh* (Amsterdam: Archis Foundation, 2007).

3 Friedrich Nietzsche, *On the Advantage and Disadvantage of History for Life,* trans. Peter Preuss (1874; reprint, Indianapolis and Cambridge, Mass.: Hackett Publishing, 1980).

4 As Nietzsche put it, in this case "there are no differences in value and no proportions for the things of the past which would truly do justice to those things in relation to each other; but only measures and proportions of those things in relation to the antiquarian individual or people looking back at them." Nietzsche, 17.

5 Nietzsche, 20.

6 Nietzsche, 19.

7 See essays in William Saunders, ed., *The New Architectural Pragmatism* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2007). This essay does not prioritize participating in the critical vs. projective debate, other than pointing out that this opposition does not have an explanatory power for Koolhaas, who has been perceived as the champion of the projective generation. I hope it will be clear at the end of the paper that, if I am

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correct about what I sense as the new direction of Koolhaas's work, this would be a shift to a critical position after a decade of more conservative geopolitics. This is not necessarily a critical practice that resists or subverts capitalist production, but an equally important criticism nevertheless. In the aim to reduce the confusion that is continuing to burden the debate by conflating political (Tafuri) and aesthetic (Eisenman) criticality, as Reinhold Martin warned in his essay in the same volume, let me make clear that I am talking about a social, political criticality, not the criticality of "autonomous architecture."

8 Nietzsche, 19.

9 Rem Koolhaas, online interview by Tom Fecht, for Hybrid Workspace (http://www.medialounge.net/lounge/workspace/main/general.html), June 26, 1997. Scholars also often criticize Koolhaas for being inconsistent and evasive. See George Baird, "An Open Letter to Rem Koolhaas," *Harvard Design Magazine* 27 (2007): 30–33.

10 Koolhaas, "Globalization," in *S,M,L,XL,* 362–69. See photograph, 362.

11 Ibid., 369.

12 Rem Koolhaas, "On the Harvard Design School Project on the City," *Harvard Design Magazine* 17 (Fall 2002–Winter 2003): 91–92.

13 Rem Koolhaas, online interview by Tom Fecht, for Hybrid Workspace (http://www.medialounge.net/lounge/workspace/main/general.html), June 26, 1997.

14 Rem Koolhaas, "Harvard Project on the City," *Mutations* (Barcelona: Actar, 2001): 116–17.

15 Aaron Betsky also commented that Koolhaas's theory on the city was original because he "extracted an essence of metropolitanism that is portable and packagable." Koolhaas defined a city that can "be built anywhere in the world." Aaron Betsky, "Rem Koolhaas: The Fire of Manhattanism Inside the Iceberg of Modernism," in *What is OMA?,* ed. Véronique Patteeuw (Rotterdam: NAi Publishers, 2003): 25–39. See quotation, 30.

16 Rem Koolhaas, "Life in the Metropolis or The Culture of Congestion" in *Architecture Theory since 1968,* ed. Michael Hays (Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press, 1998): 320–31. See quotation, 322.

17 Ibid., 322.

18 Ibid., 328.

19 Koolhaas, *S,M,L,XL,* 23–26.

20 Rem Koolhaas, *Delirious New York* (1978; reprint, New York: Monacelli Press, 1994), 123.

21 Rem Koolhaas, "Delirious No More," *Wired* (June 2003): 166–68. Interview by Charlie Rose, Charlie Rose, Public Broadcasting System.

22 Koolhaas, "The Generic City," in *S,M,L,XL,* 1248.

23 Ibid., 1248.

24 Ibid., 1250.

25 Ibid., 1250.

26 Koolhaas, "Singapore: Portrait of a Potemkin Metropolis," in *S,M,L,XL,* 1008–89. See quotation, 1011.

27 Ibid.,1077.

28 Ibid.,1057.

29 Ibid.,1073.

30 Ibid.,1087.

31 Koolhaas, "The Generic City," 1252.

32 Ibid.,1253.

33 Rem Koolhaas, online interview by Tom Fecht, for Hybrid Workspace (http://www.medialounge.net/lounge/workspace/main/general.html), June 26, 1997.

34 Koolhaas, "Pearl River Delta," in *Mutations,* 334.

35 Rem Koolhaas, "Introduction: City of Exacerbated Difference," in *Great Leap Forward: Harvard Project on the City* (Cologne: Taschen, 2001).

36 Rem Koolhaas, "Rem Koolhaas," in *Anymore,* ed. Cynthia Davidson (Cambridge, Mass., and London: MIT Press, 2000).

37 Koolhaas, "The Generic City," 1252.

38 Ibid., 1255.

39 Koolhaas, "What Ever Happened to Urbanism?," in *S,M,L,XL,* 961–71.

40 Ibid., 971.

41 Rem Koolhaas, "Junkspace," in Chuihua Judy Chung, Jeffrey Inaba, Rem Koolhaas, and Sze Tsung Leong, *Harvard Design School Guide to Shopping* (Cologne: Taschen, 2002), 408–21. Also published in *Content* (Cologne: Taschen, 2004), 162–71.

42 Koolhaas, "Junkspace," 409.

43 AMO, "Argument: Introducing...," in *Al Manakh,* 198.

44 Koolhaas, *S,M,L,XL,* 31–37.

45 Ibid., 39–40.

46 Koolhaas, "Lagos," in *Mutations,* 652.

47 Koolhaas, "Lagos," 651–700; "Rem Koolhaas," in *Anymore.*

48 Koolhaas, "Lagos," 685.

49 Koolhaas, "Frontline," in *Al Manakh,* 194.

50 Ibid., 194.

51 Koolhaas, "Lagos," 653.

52 Koolhaas, "Last Chance?", in *Al Manakh,* 7.

53 Rem Koolhaas/AMO, *The Gulf* (Stuttgart: Lars Müller Publishers, 2007). Quotation from back cover.

54 Koolhaas, "The Generic City," 1253.

55 Anthony Vidler, "Psychometropolis," in *Architectural Uncanny: Essays in the Modern Unhomely* (Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press, 1992), 192.

56 "Ecological Footprint per Capita" (map produced by AMO), in *Al Manakh,* 71. Estimates for the size of these landfill projects are alarming: 1.1 billion cubic meters of sand and stone are to be filled in water, 520 kilometers of beaches are to be constructed for The Palm; 232 kilometers of shoreline will be created for The World islands. As promoters of the project proudly state, the whole city of Venice fits into just a quarter of The World (*Al Manakh,* 275). The damaging effects of these megascale artificial islands on the microclimate of the oasis or the ecology of the Gulf water are yet to be analyzed.

57 Koolhaas, "Singapore," 1082–83.

58 The research on Orientalism in literature and visual arts is quite comprehensive. The foundational book that shifted the paradigm and rose a critical consciousness against the separatist, exoticizing, and ultimately imperialist impacts of Orientalist studies was Edward Said's book *Orientalism.* Edward Said, *Orientalism* (New York: Vintage Books, 1978).

59 Koolhaas, "The Generic City," 1263.

60 Koolhaas, "Learning Japanese," in *S,M,L,XL,* 1006.

61 George Packer, "The Megacity: Decoding the Chaos of Lagos," *New Yorker* (November 3, 2006): 62–75. See quotation: 66, 75.

62 Okwui Enwezor, "Terminal Modernity: Rem Koolhaas's Discourse on Entropy," in *What is OMA?,* ed. Véronique Patteeuw (Rotterdam: NAi Publishers, 2003): 103–19. See quotation, 113, 116.

63 Koolhaas, *Mutations,* 718, 653.

64 AMO's book *Lagos: How it Works* was not published, and the manuscript was not ready for review during the writing of this essay. These ideas are thus based on Koolhaas's and AMO's earlier articles and lectures on Lagos.

65 Koolhaas, "Gulf Survey," in *Al Manakh,* 138.

66 For more about the differentiation between a migrant and a nomad traveler, see: Esra Akcan, "Nomads and Migrants: A Comparative Reading of Sedad Eldem's and Le Corbusier's Travel Diaries," in *Travel Space and Architecture,* eds. Jilly Traganou, Miodrag Mitrasinovic, and Samer Akkach (Aldershot, U.K.: Ashgate, forthcoming).

67 Rem Koolhaas, ". . . If," in *Content* (Cologne: Taschen, 2004). Originally written in May 2003.

68 Talia Dorsey, interview by author, April 16, 2008.

69 Koolhaas and Reiner de Graaf, "The Future of Knowledge," in *Al Manakh,* 329.

70 Koolhaas, "Last Chance?", 7.

71 Roemer van Toorn, "No More Dreams? The Passion for Reality in Recent Dutch Architecture and Its Limitations," in *The New Architectural Pragmatism,* ed. William Saunders (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2007), 54–74. See quote, 54, 55, 60.

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